

ARCHITECTURE: AIA HONORS LIST

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ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

AIA honors list

Spring brings flowers, honorary, degrees and architectural awards.

The biggest prizes are the Honor Awards of the American Institute of Architects, to be handed out at the AIA's convention this week in San Diego.

There are 17 this year, the most ever, reflecting a general trend toward inflation in the prize game. Fashions come and go, of course, and this year beetle-browed concrete is down, supplanted by seal-slick metal and glass on the one hand and hairy old sandblasted brick on the other.

Five of the 17 winners are either in New England or designed by New England architects, the usual good showing by our hotbed of semi-employed design talent.

Local winner in the Flashy-Glassy school is the controversial John Hancock Tower, by I.M. Pei and Partners (Henry Cobb designer), upping this firm's take of AIA honor awards to a record 16.

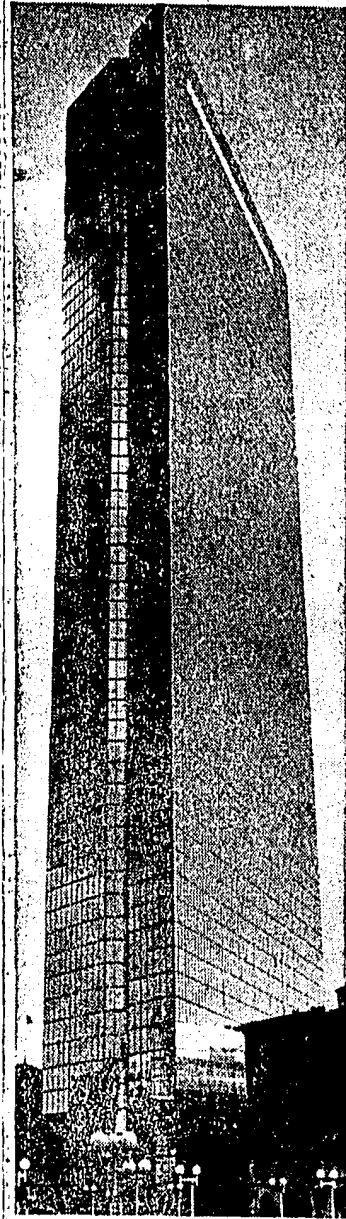
In the Very Hairy category, local

firms won with two renovations: the granite Mercantile Block on the waterfront by John Sharratt, and New Melleray Abbey in Iowa done in part by Willoughby Marshall of Cambridge.

Other New England-connected winners are a house in Mt. Desert, Maine, by Edward Larrabee Barnes, and a student center at Vassar by Shepley Bulfinch Richardson Abbott.

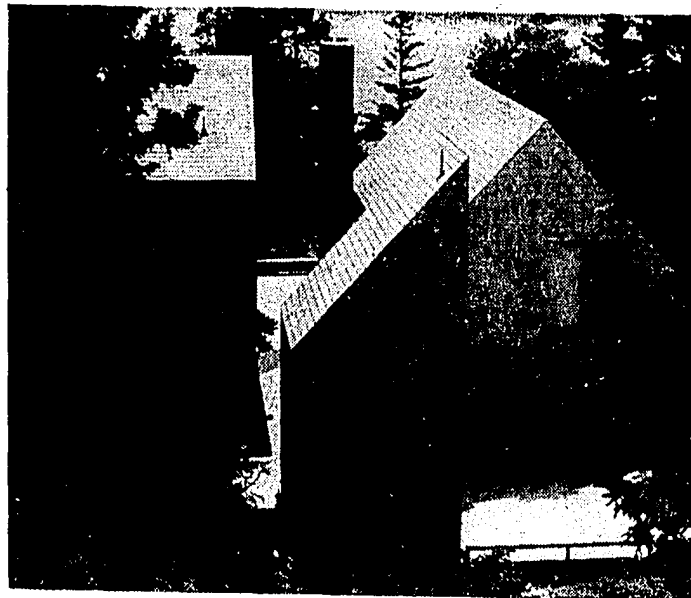
The rest are too numerous to list, but include such notable buildings as Philip Johnson's pointy-head Pennzoil Place in Houston; Richard Meier's Bronx Developmental Center; Pei's Spelman Halls at Princeton; Mitchell-Giurgola's Penn Mutual Tower in Philly, which incorporates an old building's facade into a new tower; and such Bare-the-Brick renovations as Canal Square in Washington and Navy Pier in Chicago.

For the AIA it's a fairly eclectic list, though the only building that offers anything new is Meier's amazing, shining aluminum, intricately fitted Tinkertoy. If seductive elegance made architecture, this building would be a classic.



Of the John Hancock Tower, the AIA jury said: 'This was a difficult building to prelate because of the adverse publicity. However... it catches the sun, reflects the sky, and acts as an effective new landmark for downtown Boston. It is perhaps the most handsome reflective glass building; history may show it to be the last great example.'

(Globe photo by William Ryerson)



Vacation house in Maine is broken into four separate small shed-like pieces on a common wood deck. Said jury: 'Modesty in building is a delightful virtue.'

(David Franzen photo)



Mercantile Wharf Building was called 'a brilliant solution: by opening up the center of the structure as a multi-

level open core and garden atrium, the architects have created an exciting atmosphere.' (Steve Rosenthal photo)